

Whip-poor-will Chick Plumage Stages

Day 0-2



- Covered in brown natal down
- Most noticeable differences will be in measurements

Day 8-10



- Feathers emerging from sheaths on wings (flight feathers and coverts) and tail
- Appearance of pin feathers on head

Day 3-4



- First appearance of pin feathers on wings and shoulders
- Wings begin to darken due to pin flight feathers

Day 11-13



- Feathers emerging from sheaths on head
- Tail feather emergence still minor
- Flight feathers growing, feather sheaths still visible on top of wing

Day 5-7



- Pin feathers in most body feather tracts, appearance of pin tail feathers
- Appearance of rectal bristles
- Starting to lose natal down

Day 14-15



- Head mostly feathered
- Flight feathers continuing to grow, feather sheaths no longer visible from top of wing
- Tail feathers continuing to grow, noticeable feather exposure

Whip-poor-will Chick Age Estimation

To estimate the age of a chick, check the blank box(s) next to each measurement range (mean in parentheses) that encompasses the field measurement. More than one box (age) for each measurement may be checked in which the age determination will be a range of ages. Most accurate estimates of age (within 1-2 days) require measures of mass, tarsus length, humerus length, and wing length. When all 4 measurements are made, the estimated age of the chick is obtained by adding the 4 measurement values together and dividing by 4 to get a unitless value estimate that can be compared to the measurement ranges in the last column.

Day	Mass ¹		Tarsus Length ¹		Humerus Length ²		Wing Length ¹		Combined Value	
0	3.0–7.5 (4.9)		6.5–10.7 (8.3)		5.2–11.9 (8.6)		4.5–12.0 (7.1)		5.9–8.9 (7.3)	
1	4.9–10.0 (7.2)		8.0–11.9 (9.6)		7.4–14.5 (11.1)		7.1–16.1 (10.3)		8.0–11.4 (9.6)	
2	7.3–12.8 (9.9)		9.3–12.9 (10.9)		9.9–17.0 (13.7)		10.5–20.9 (14.1)		10.4–14.2 (12.1)	
3	10.0–15.8 (12.8)		10.6–13.9 (12.0)		12.5–19.5 (16.3)		14.6–26.3 (18.7)		13.1–17.2 (14.9)	
4	13.0–18.8 (15.9)		11.6–14.7 (13.0)		15.1–21.8 (18.8)		19.3–32.1 (23.8)		16.0–20.3 (17.9)	
5	16.2–21.9 (19.1)		12.6–15.4 (13.8)		17.7–23.9 (21.1)		24.6–38.2 (29.4)		19.0–23.4 (20.9)	
6	19.3–24.9 (22.3)		13.4–16.0 (14.6)		20.1–25.8 (23.3)		30.3–44.4 (35.3)		22.0–26.5 (23.9)	
7	22.3–27.9 (25.3)		14.0–16.5 (15.2)		22.4–27.5 (25.3)		36.3–50.7 (41.5)		25.0–29.4 (26.8)	
8	25.1–30.9 (28.1)		14.6–16.9 (15.8)		24.4–29.0 (27.0)		42.4–57.0 (47.7)		27.8–32.2 (29.6)	
9	27.7–33.6 (30.6)		15.1–17.3 (16.3)		26.2–30.3 (28.5)		48.5–63.1 (53.8)		30.5–34.9 (32.3)	
10	30.0–36.1 (33.0)		15.6–17.6 (16.7)		27.7–31.4 (29.8)		54.5–68.9 (59.8)		33.1–37.3 (34.8)	
11	32.1–38.4 (35.0)		15.9–17.9 (17.0)		29.1–32.4 (30.9)		60.2–74.4 (65.5)		35.4–39.6 (37.1)	
12	33.8–40.4 (36.8)		16.2–18.1 (17.3)		30.2–33.3 (31.9)		65.6–79.6 (71.0)		37.6–41.6 (39.3)	
13	35.2–42.1 (38.4)		16.4–18.4 (17.5)		31.1–34.0 (32.7)		70.7–84.5 (76.1)		39.5–43.5 (41.2)	
14	36.4–43.7 (39.8)		16.6–18.6 (17.7)		31.9–34.7 (33.4)		75.4–89.0 (80.9)		41.2–45.2 (42.9)	
15	37.4–45.0 (41.0)		16.8–18.7 (17.8)		32.5–35.2 (34.0)		79.7–93.1 (85.2)		42.8–46.8 (44.5)	

¹Measurements taken as shown in Identification Guide to North American Birds (Pyle 1997)

²Length of humerus measured from the tip of the bone at the shoulder to the tip of the bone at the elbow